

Remembering Tony de Sa

Teacher, educator,
self-taught programmer,
editorial assistant.



Halfway through the interview being taped for a podcast, he said to me, “Thank you....” and was quite ready to leave. I had to tell him, “No, no. I’ve not finished with you.” He laughed, and continued to make a good number of more points.

That was the ever-modest Tony de Sa for you.

My friend, close associate, free software/open source fellow traveller for maybe two decades, and collaborator in an unusual, altruistic venture, Tony de Sa, passed away unexpectedly on September 28. Anthony de Sa, whom everyone called simply Tony, also helped to remotely sub-edit this *Open Source For You* magazine for a long while from his river-surrounded village in North Goa’s Bardez sub-district.

Tony was 73 and died of complications related to Covid.

* * *

We first met when the Goa chapter of the India Linux Users Group was among its most active, in the early 2000s, if one recalls right. To call it a ‘chapter’ might be a bit of an exaggeration. It was a simple, informal group that met when it felt like, and didn’t have any formal leadership structure. Everyone just did what they could. And it worked.

Using programmer’s logic, a few techies, mainly in Bengaluru and Delhi, had thought of a neat way to spread the ILUG movement then. They did so by building ILUG clones in diverse cities. Each was named with the same initials (ILUG), and the city-name or state-name was added to it.

When our group grew a bit weary of itself and reduced its activity, Tony was still there, hanging on. I remember him as invariably being among the three to four members to valiantly show up at meets. He would do so whether that was for some serious meeting or simply for a cup of tea at Cafe Prakash in Panjim, not far from the Mandovi River. He would routinely post something useful and helpful via mailing lists and WhatsApp groups.

From over dozens of face-to-face chats, both short and long, I have pieced together (only a part of) Tony’s long, colourful story.

Interesting among these details is how this science graduate spent a lifetime in teaching Maths and Physics, and rose to become the headmaster of a historic, age-old school in the village of Parra, in North Goa.

(Over the years, the Sacred Heart High School of Verla-Parra had not been able to sustain its earlier fame, and Tony was among those who helped it regain some of its shine. His former students recall him fondly. Milena Marques Zachariaiah, who runs a Konkani language podcast programme called *Radio Mango* from distant Canada, narrated to me how Tony had confiscated a Harold Robbins novel she was reading and returned it to her after she finished her SSC exam. All his students speak highly of him as a motivator.)

More than that, after finishing his teaching career, he taught himself programming (“dabbled in HTML, Python and a few others here and there”). He would venture into new fields on a regular basis, and lifelong learning was not just a catchphrase for him.

After retiring, he did not waste a minute. If not volunteering somewhere, he would be doing freelance work or learning something new. That is how his association with open source and free software came about.

At one point, we were talking about deploying his teacher-motivation talent in Goa, in a form of skill-upgradation the classroom badly needed. This didn’t quite happen. But the conversation perhaps helped shape up other initiatives like the free-and-open initiative of online 100-minute capsule classes being currently held via the Collaborative Learning Cafe [facebook.com/groups/clcgoa] in Goa.